

INTELLIGENCE BRIEF / N° 223 · HOT

Helsing

Defence Technology · AI Software / Autonomous Systems · Munich · Private (\$18B reported; \$1.2B round in close, May 2026)

Helsing, Munich's defence-AI company, was reported on 11 May 2026 to be closing a \$1.2B round led by Dragoneer at an \$18B valuation, eleven weeks after the Bundestag approved its first HX-2 strike-drone contract for the Bundeswehr. Germany's most valuable startup, by that print, is entering its build phase.

71

OPPORTUNITY / 100

TIMING WINDOW

WARM

SERIES

F1

RECOMMENDED TEAM

Audi Revolut F1 Team

ACTION HORIZON

6-10 WKS

THE CASE

TechCrunch reported on 11 May that Helsing was in the final close of a \$1.2B round led by Dragoneer and co-led by Lightspeed at an \$18B valuation, up from the ~€12B set by its €600M Series D under Daniel Ek's Prima Materia in June 2025. Order flow has arrived to match the capital: on 25 February the Bundestag budget committee approved a €269M initial HX-2 contract with a framework of up to €1.46B over seven years, inside a 4,300-drone first tranche. The round later closed at \$1.8B on 13 July.

Defence is not new to the paddock: Boeing sits on Alpine's roster and BAE Systems shares fast-jet technology with Williams. What is new is a European defence company with venture capital at this scale and a hiring problem, competing with the primes and the hyperscalers for the same engineers. Formula 1 is Europe's most-watched engineering shop floor, and no defence-technology company has a seat in it.

WHY NOW

The round was reported in final close on 11 May and closed at \$1.8B in July; the HX-2 contract was approved on 25 February. Budget and brand motive crest in the same year, and Audi's first Formula 1 season leaves a German partner roster still being written.

PROOF POINTS — EVERY FIGURE VERIFIED TO A PRIMARY SOURCE (SEE P.2)

\$1.2B

\$1.2B round at an \$18B valuation reported entering final close, led by Dragoneer and co-led by Lightspeed (...)

€600M

Dragoneer (lead, reported), Lightspeed; prior €600M Series D led by Prima Materia at ~€12B in June 2025 wit...

€269M

Order flow has arrived to match the capital: on 25 February the Bundestag budget committee approved a €269M...

\$1.8B

The round later closed at \$1.8B on 13 July.

\$18B

An \$18B valuation, a Bundestag-approved €269M HX-2 contract with a €1.46B framework, and a hiring race agai...

GRID FIT — CATEGORY-WHITESPACE CHECK ACROSS THE F1 GRID (SPONSOR TABLE; 49 OF 346 PARTNER ROWS CATEGORISED)

Audi Revolut F1 Team	OPEN	no rival in this category lane
Mercedes-AMG Petronas F1 Team	OPEN	no rival in this category lane
Oracle Red Bull Racing	OPEN	no rival in this category lane
Scuderia Ferrari HP	OPEN	no rival in this category lane

BOTTOM LINE

An \$18B valuation, a Bundestag-approved €269M HX-2 contract with a €1.46B framework, and a hiring race against the primes give Helsing budget and motive at the same moment. Audi's debut roster has no defence or security partner, and the Bavarian pairing is the opening.

WHY AUDI REVOLUT F1 TEAM

Audi's 2026 entry is a German works programme: power units from Neuburg an der Donau in Bavaria, chassis from Hinwil and a technology centre in Bicester. Its partner roster carries Revolut as title partner and Extreme Networks, NinjaOne, ElevenLabs and JigSpace on the technology side; there is no defence, aerospace or security partner. A Bavarian engineering pairing in Audi's debut season is a story both boards can tell.

VALUE TO AUDI REVOLUT F1 TEAM — MODE B (TECH SERVES THE TEAM OPERATION)

MODE B - halo with concrete mechanics. Talent: Helsing and Audi's Neuburg, Hinwil and Bicester sites recruit the same software, autonomy and hardware engineers; a joint graduate and secondment programme is a real, fundable workstream. Access: paddock hospitality for ministry and NATO-market delegations at the European rounds. Brand: a made-in-Europe engineering narrative on a German car in its first season.

DEAL ARCHITECTURE

Entry as Official Defence Technology Partner. **THREE YEARS**, 2027-2029, covering the HX-2 production ramp and a likely listing window. Estimated \$3-5M a year. Scope: sidepod or engine-cover placement, a joint engineering-talent programme across Neuburg, Hinwil and Bicester, European-round hospitality for government customers, and a recruitment content series.

PRIMARY DECISION-MAKER

Torsten Reil

CO-FOUNDER & CO-CEO, HELSING · VERIFIED

Reil co-founded Helsing in 2021 and shares the CEO role with Gundbert Scherf; he previously founded NaturalMotion, the Oxford games studio behind CSR Racing, sold to Zynga for \$527M in 2014. Path: Johannes Boie, Chief Marketing Officer and Communications; Anita Szarek, CFO; Niklas Köhler, President.

OPENING ANGLE

Lead with the talent war, not the logo.

“Torsten, you are hiring the same engineers Audi needs for Neuburg and Bicester, and no defence company has a seat on the grid. Audi's first season is being written now. 25 minutes to see how a Bavarian pairing would work?”

SCORE COMPOSITION

TIMING 16 / 20 Round reported 11 May; HX-2 approval 25 Feb; European rounds ahead.	CAPACITY 18 / 20 \$18B valuation; \$1.2B in close (closed at \$1.8B in July).	BRAND FIT 12 / 20 Deep-tech engineering brand; weapons category is board-sensitive.	URGENCY 12 / 20 No listing date; talent race is real but not calendar-bound.	OPS FIT 13 / 20 MODE B: talent programme and government hospitality; no on-car workstream.
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RISKS & COUNTERS

CATEGORY SENSITIVITY A munitions maker on a car is a board-level decision for Audi and the VW Group; the Boeing and BAE precedents are aerospace, not weapons. **Counter:** Frame it around software, autonomy and talent; agree branding guidelines before the term sheet.

REPORTED AT THE ROW DATE On 11 May the \$1.2B round was press-reported, not announced; Helsing publishes no revenue. **Counter:** Anchor on the approved contract and the July close; put the round on the record in the first call.

SOURCES — 15 OF 15 LOAD-BEARING CLAIMS VERIFIED

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